

Session 29: The Meaning of the Great Fish

Key Takeaways

- In the Bible, giant sea creatures like the one that swallowed Jonah are dangerous, but they are totally within God's control.
- Jonah's time in the fish is portrayed as a kind of death. But will this passage through death into new life change him? That's the big question explored in the last chapter of Jonah.

Narrative Structure of Jonah's Prayer

A 1:17a And **Yahweh** appointed a great **fish** to **swallow Jonah**,

B 1:17b and Jonah was in the inner-parts of the fish for three days and three nights.

B' 2:1 And Jonah prayed to Yahweh from the inner-parts of the fish.

2:2-9 **[Jonah's Prayer]**

A' 2:10 And **Yahweh** spoke to the **fish**, and it **vomited Jonah** to the dry land.

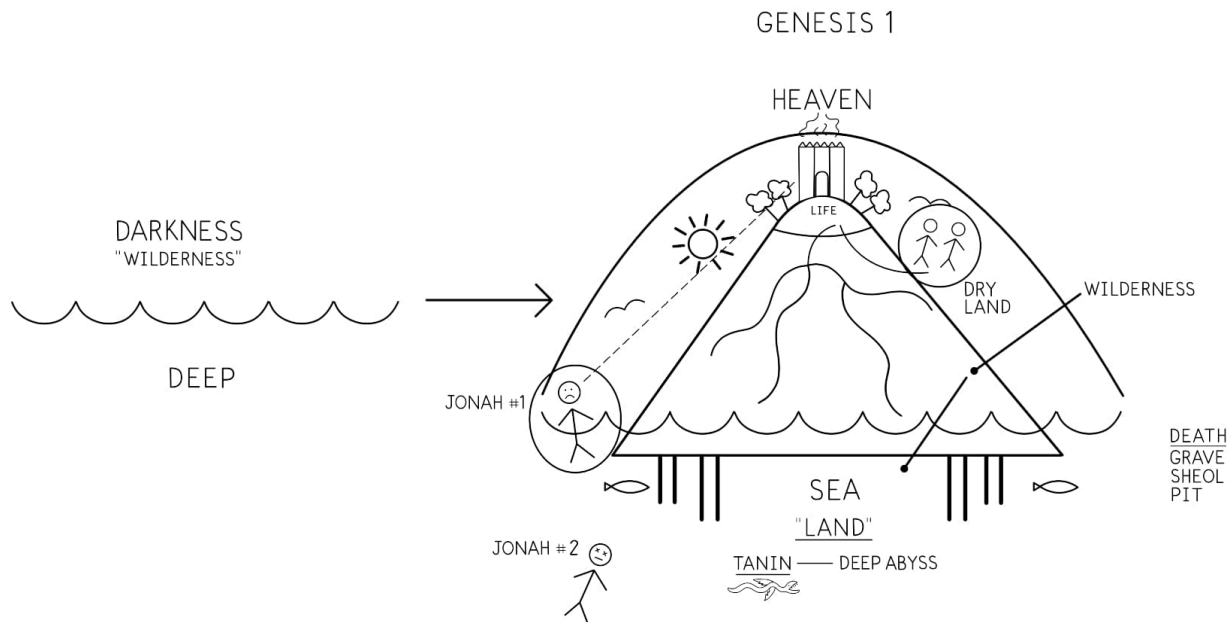
Jonah 1:17-2:10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The Great Fish

The biblical authors were well aware of great, monstrous creatures in the deep sea. They were considered deities among Israel's neighbors, but for the biblical authors, they were extremely powerful creatures who were under the rule of their Creator.

Great Sea Creatures in the Hebrew Bible

Genesis 1 provides the foundation for understanding the ancient cosmology of the biblical authors. Here we are introduced to the important creature of the sea monster/sea dragon (Heb. *tannin* / תנין) and Leviathan as



A Hebrew Understanding of the Cosmos in Genesis 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Genesis 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ Then God said, “Let the waters teem with swarms of living creatures, and let birds fly above the earth in the open expanse of the heavens.” ²¹ God created the great sea monsters and every living creature that moves, with which the waters swarmed after their kind ...

Later in [Genesis 1:26](#), God commissions his human images to “rule over the fish (Heb. *dag* / גֹּדֶל) of the sea.” So in the narrative sequence of Genesis 1, the sea monsters are associated with the “fish of the sea.” This explains why the author of Jonah has him swallowed by a “great fish” instead of a “great sea monster.”

In the Old Greek translation, “sea monster” in [Genesis 1:21](#) was translated as *κῆτος* (sea monster), precisely the same way the Greek translators of [Jonah 1:17](#) translated the phrase “the great fish” (Heb. גֹּדֶל הַדָּג) “the great sea monster” (*κῆτος μέγας*).

Psalms 104:24-27 NASB*

²⁴ O LORD, how many are your works! ...

²⁵ There is the sea, great and broad,
in which are swarms without number,
animals both small and great.

²⁶ There the ships move along,
and Leviathan, which you have formed to play in it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 148:7-8 NASB*

⁷ Praise the LORD from the earth,
Sea monsters [Hebrew: *tannin* / Old Greek: δράκον] and all the depths,
⁸ fire and hail, snow and clouds;
stormy wind, fulfilling his word;

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The terms leviathan (Heb. לִיָּתָן) and *tannin* were adopted from the mythological imagery of Israel's neighbors to refer to human and spiritual forces of evil and chaos. The biblical authors adopted this imagery and applied it to their conviction that Yahweh alone is the one who defeats the powers of evil and chaos.

Isaiah 51:9-10 NASB*

⁹ Awake, awake, put on strength, O arm of the LORD;
awake as in the days of old, the generations of long ago.
Was it not you who cut Rahab in pieces,
who pierced the sea monster?
¹⁰ Was it not you who dried up the sea,
the waters of the great deep;
who made the depths of the sea a pathway
for the redeemed to cross over?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 74:12-14 NASB

¹² Yet God is my king from of old,
who works deeds of deliverance in the midst of the earth.
¹³ You divided the sea by your strength;
you broke the heads of the sea monsters in the waters.
¹⁴ you crushed the heads of Leviathan ...

"The great fish is a comic version of an ancient nightmare, the great monster of the deep that represents chaos and destruction, the flooding and undoing of the world ... In bearing witness to the power of the God of Israel, Scripture often reckons with the nightmares of ancient near eastern mythology and puts the images to its own uses ... In Jonah the nightmare is turned into comedy. The creature that swallows Jonah up is not one of the terrible monsters of the deep ... but just a great big fish ... Call it a monster if you wish, it's no big deal. Wherever you go in the world, the LORD who created it is there before you and can prepare a way for you, even if the way is a great big fish."

Cary, Phillip (2008), [*Jonah*](#). Brazos Press. 76.

There are two other biblical texts that depict Israel's ancient enemies as the sea monster, and one of them is the only other passage where a great sea creature swallows someone alive.

Ezekiel 29:3 NASB*

"Thus says the Lord God,
'Behold, I am against you, Pharaoh king of Egypt,
the great sea monster that lies in the midst of his rivers ...'"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Egypt

Jeremiah 51:34 NASB*

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon has devoured me, crushed me,
he has set me down as an empty vessel;
he has swallowed me like a sea monster;
he has filled his stomach with my delicacies;
he has washed me away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Babylon

This fits with other instances in biblical poetry of Israel being "swallowed up," which is consistently an image of being overcome by enemy nations.

Psalms 124:2-5 NIV*

² If the LORD had not been on our side
when humans attacked us,
³ they would have swallowed us alive
when their anger flared against us;
⁴ the flood would have engulfed us,
the torrent would have swept over us,
⁵ the arrogant waters
would have swept us away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See [Exodus 18:11](#)

Lamentations 2:16 NASB

All your enemies
have opened their mouths wide against you;
they hiss and gnash their teeth;
they say, "We have swallowed her up!"

Hosea 8:8 NASB

Israel is swallowed up;
they are now among the nations
like a vessel in which no one delights.

See also [Psalm 35:25](#) and [Isaiah 49:19](#)

The story of Jonah has drawn together all of these images of Egypt and Babylon as great sea monsters swallowing God's people into exile and slavery. But God's power can protect his people despite their "submarine death" so that a re-created people can emerge out the other side (as in [Ezek. 37](#)).

"The original readers of Jonah would have seen these connections right away: long ago Israel passed safely through the sea in their exodus from Egypt, and more recently Israel was swallowed up by the greatest beast of them all, Babylon the great, which the prophet Jeremiah calls "the great monster that has swallowed me up" ([Jer 51:34](#)) ... And yet, after being swallowed up by Babylon, the remnant of Israel was kept safe in the belly of Babylon (see the stories of Daniel or [Jeremiah 29](#)). Jonah swallowed up by a sea monster is a parallel image to the Jewish people going into exile, yet still alive and still having a future as they sings songs in the belly of the beast ..."

Adapted from Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 76-77.

Early Artwork of Jonah's Great Fish

Mosaics from fourth century C.E., Basilica Patriarchale in Aquileia, Italy



Agricola, Peter (2009). Jonah and the sea-monster (Ketos). [Flickr](#).



HEN-Magonza (2021). Aquileia, Basilica, floor mosaic, Jonah thrown on the beach. [Flickr](#).

Sixth century stone-carved door lintel and fourth century Coptic tapestry from Monastery of Bawit in Upper Egypt (Louvre, Paris)



Korshi (2019). Unknown. [CopticMagicalPapyri](#).



Korshi (2019). Unknown. [CopticMagicalPapyri](#).

From the catacomb of St. Priscilla, Rome (2nd-4th century C.E.)



Leinad, Creative Commons (2006). Jonah thrown into the Sea. [Wikimedia](#).

Reflection Question

What kinds of things does the author want us to understand when we read that Jonah is swallowed by a fish?
What are the biblical ideas related to large sea creatures that the author is assuming we know?